

A LIFELONG AFFAIR

A devotee analyses the magic of the Mumbai film industry in an account as eclectic and colourful as its films



**SEDUCED BY THE FAMILIAR:
NARRATION AND MEANING IN
INDIAN POPULAR CINEMA**
by M.K. RAGHAVENDRA
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■ By Kaverie Bamzai

Sometimes, the simplest things are the most difficult to do. On the face of it, *Seduced by the Familiar*—a freewheeling journey through Hindi cinema—seems like a superlatively dufferish idea. What could be easier than studying the progress of a nation through the stories told by its most popular cinema? Well, the surprise is that few books have set themselves such an ambitious task and fewer have succeeded. So if you haven't already been underwhelmed by the multitude of books being churned out about Bollywood, M.K. Raghavendra's work, clearly the result of several years and not borne of the overnight desire to cash in on a growing global fad, is just perfect for anyone who loves Hindi cinema and wants more than a handful of glossy pictures and reams of glassy-eyed prose.

Imagine Ashish Rajadhyaksha and Paul Willemen's excellent *Encyclopaedia of Indian Cinema* as an unbroken narrative and you'll understand the felicity with which this book moves from a discussion of space in Mehboob Khan's *Andaz*, 1949, to the domain of action in Sooraj Barjatya's *Hum Aapke Hain Koun...*! (1994), from the murder in Bimal Roy's *Bandini*, 1963, to the courtroom scene in Vijay Anand's *Guide*, 1965. There are some enjoyable interpretations of some of India's best loved movies. Some assessments can leave you scratching your head (the tussle within the family in *Aag*, 1948, reflects the battle for political control between Jawaharlal Nehru and Vallabhbhai Patel!) while others can leave you wanting to do something more drastic (according to Raghavendra, Nargis's surrender to Raj Kapoor in *Barsaat*, 1949, represents the accession of Kashmir to

India). Some ideas have been done to death (the issue of patricide in *Awaara*, 1951) while others are breathtakingly radical (*Baiju Bawra*, 1952, is a critique of the modern, independent state). It may give readers a start to see the 1970s, a decade normally always associated with Amitabh Bachchan, in the broader context of the woman on trial at a time when India was being helmed politically by an iron lady. Or to read about the films of the furious '80s, a decade usually neglected by critics and notable for several particularly bad films. But in all cases, the readings are worthy of

whose *Kala Pani*, 1958, is seen as best evoking the changing times it was situated in) while some films have been rescued from obscurity (Raj Kapoor's much-overlooked *Aah*, 1953, which symbolises the Nehruvian dream). From the emerging modern woman of B.R. Chopra's *Dhool ka Phool*, 1959, to the tourist guide in *Guide* showing a commodified version of Indian culture, the book is innovative in its explorations. And while the first chapter can be a bit of a yawn, it does have the virtue of possibly making you sound intelligent at the most intellectual of film gatherings.



ART OF PERFECTION: A still from *Shree 420* featuring Kapoor and Nargis

debate, which is probably the best thing a creative work can aspire to.

The movie explores several ideas—the family, the nation, the idea of the modern city, the later withdrawal of the parent figure, and the birth of the global nation. Practically every important Mumbai filmmaker's work has been analysed and assessed, with some refreshing insights into their oeuvre. Some directors have been given their due place in the pantheon of greats (Raj Khosla, for instance,

A word of caution though. This is not a book for those looking for beginner-level thrills in the exciting world of Bollywood. It supposes a certain level of understanding of Hindi cinema, assuming the reader is as familiar with V. Shantaram's *Aadmi*, 1939, as with Abbas-Mustan's *Baazigar*, 1993, between which it sees similarities. The best education would be to watch the movies, of course. Black and white or in glorious technicolor, cinema is truly seductive. And the best books on movies—such as this—just make you want to watch more of them. ■